

Charge Trap Analysis in an Underground SENSEI Skipper-CCD: Understanding Low-Energy Backgrounds in Rare-Event Searches 2

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Skipper Charge-Coupled Devices (Skipper-CCDs) are detectors that have sub-eV resolution, making them a critical technology for rare event searches. A major challenge in experiments using these detectors is mitigating low-energy backgrounds. One such background potentially arises from single-electron charge traps caused by lattice defects. In this work we present and use a new technique for generating uniform charge across the CCD to study single electron traps in a SENSEI sensor placed underground in the MINOS tunnel at Fermilab. The underground shielding allows us to make use of the pocket pumping technique to probe traps with emission times $> 10^8$ seconds, a measurement that was never possible before. We fully characterize a significant fraction of the identified traps and use this information to extrapolate their contribution to the single-electron background in SENSEI. We find that the studied population of traps does not significantly impact the single electron rate measured by SENSEI.

I. TRAPS AND SINGLE-ELECTRON BACKGROUNDS

Skipper-Charge-Coupled-Devices (Skipper-CCDs) are pixelated silicon detectors that are widely used in rare-event searches [1–4]. They are enhanced versions of CCDs that can perform repeated non-destructive measurements of output charge and consequently achieve sub-electron resolution [5], enabling sensitivity to particles that produce one or few electrons when they interact with the bulk silicon.

The SENSEI and DAMIC experiments have achieved world leading results in the search for light dark matter, and significant efforts are underway to scale up these detectors and mitigate backgrounds [6–11]. These backgrounds which may arise from environmental effects [7, 12, 13] or intrinsic processes within the sensor [14, 15], and characterizing them will be key to maximizing sensitivity.

Results from the OSCURA collaboration [16, 17] have indicated that contaminants or defects in the silicon lattice of the Skipper-CCD can trap and release charge. Charge from high energy interactions may become trapped and later released, therefore acting as a potential source of single-electron backgrounds. More recently, measurements were performed at LAMBDA 80

Laboratory at the University of Buenos Aires surface on a CCD fabricated from the same wafer as science-grade SENSEI CCDs [18]. These measurements suggested that current analysis strategies may mitigate the effect of trapped charge. However, these measurements were taken at surface, thus limiting the measurement from accurately probing very long lived traps. Generally, the emission time of these traps decreases as a function of temperature, and thus to probe very long-lived traps (traps that emit electrons several days or even months after the initial trapping) at the usual operating temperature of ~ 135 K it is important to take longer measurements at higher operating temperatures. At the surface you are limited in how long your measurements can be due to the high rate of backgrounds from cosmic rays or environmental sources.

Thus in this work we performed measurements a SENSEI CCD that was used in a recent science run [19]. The Skipper-CCD is made of high-resistivity silicon with an active area of 6144×1024 pixels each of size 15×15 μ housed in a vacuum chamber equipped with a vacuum pump and a cryocooler. The CCD has four readout amplifiers that each read out in parallel a “quadrant” of 512 rows by 3072 columns. The CCD was operated and read out with a Low-Threshold-Acquisition board (LTA) [20]. The location of this CCD, underground in

the MINOS Cavern at Fermilab, enabled measurements at high temperatures in a clean environment, and which allowed us to probe the population of traps with longer emission times. In Section II we describe a new technique used to uniformly illuminate the CCD and the subsequent measurements taken to study traps. We describe in Section III how traps were identified and in Section IV the trap energy and temperature dependence. We conclude in Section VI with the impact of the trap density on single-electron backgrounds in SENSEI and compare with previous results.

II. CHARGE GENERATION AND POCKET-PUMPING MEASUREMENTS

Unlike in the previous work, we did not use an LED to uniformly illuminate the CCD. Instead we took advantage of a feature inherent to CCDs known as spurious charge. Spurious charge is generated when the voltages of pixels in the active area are changed when shifting charge to neighboring pixels [21]. The charge scales linearly with the number of shifts performed, and exponentially with the voltage clock swing, as expected from [21]. Therefore by performing symmetric back-and-forth shifts with high voltage swing (charge-generating shifts), charge can be generated uniformly across the CCD in a controlled, reproducible manner. In this work we used a voltage swing of 10 V and 100,000 shifts to generate approximately 2000 e^- of charge per pixel.

The pocket-pumping technique, described in detail in [17] involves uniformly illuminating the CCD and then repeatedly moving the charge back and forth between the three pixel phases. If a trap exists in the edge phases, charges may be captured and released at a later time, spilling into the neighbor and creating a “dipole” signal relative to the uniform background. The number of charge carriers trapped and released, or in other words the intensity of the dipole ($I_{t_{ph}}$) is defined as half the difference in charge between the two pixels. The intensity depends on the number of pump cycles N_{pumps} and the duration of each clock state t_{ph} .

The measurement procedure was as follows: for a given temperature, charge-generating shifts were performed as described above to uniformly illuminate the CCD with charge. Then the pocket-pumping protocol was performed with $N_{\text{pumps}} = 3000$ to obtain well-defined non-saturated dipoles for various t_{ph} . At a given temperature t_{ph} was varied from approximately 5×10^{-5} s to 1.03 s. Only one skipper sample was taken to speed up readout time. Temperature was varied from [125, 210] K with 18-25 images at each temperature. We specifically took longer t_{ph} measurements at higher temperatures to maximize sensitivity to longer trap emission times.

III. TRAP CHARACTERIZATION

The dipole intensity depends on N_{pumps} , t_{ph} , the probability of capturing a charge carrier P_c and the probability of emitting a charge carrier P_e [17, 22, 23]. P_c acts as a scaling factor that varies with temperature, and P_e can be expressed as a function of the emission characteristic time $\tau_e(T)$. This gives:

$$I(t_{ph}) = N_{\text{pumps}} D_t P_c \left(e^{-\frac{t_{ph}}{\tau_e}} - e^{-8\frac{t_{ph}}{\tau_e}} \right) \quad (1)$$

Trap identification is performed using the same algorithm described in [18]. Once a trap is identified it was logged in each image taken at the same temperature, obtaining its intensity for each t_{ph} . For images taken at a given temperature (T) the intensity $I(t_{ph})$ of an identified trap for various delay times t_{ph} can be plotted to predict the trap’s emission time constant $\tau_e(T)$. If a trap only appears at one t_{ph} value it is ignored.

Fits are then performed according to Eq. 1 for the identified traps. Following this criteria 60,029 dipoles are identified associated with 5171 traps. We analyze as before the spatial distribution of these identified traps using toy Monte-Carlo simulations. 10^4 simulations were performed under the assumption of spatial uniformity. Fig. 1 shows the histogram of the distances between all identified traps per quadrant, along with the simulation result and its corresponding 90% confidence band assuming the traps are distributed uniformly. Some deviation from uniformity is expected due to the spatially localized nature of the cause of traps (defects in the CCD, high energy events, etc), but in general we see good agreement with this simulation.

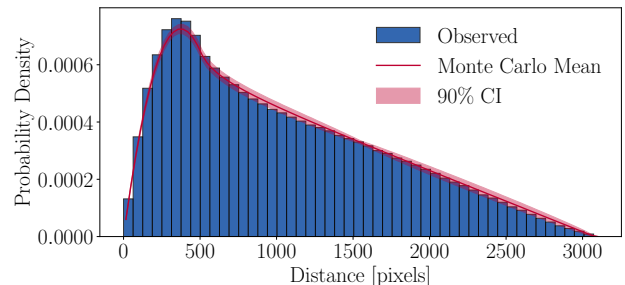


FIG. 1. Probability density of the distance between all identified traps, combining all four quadrants. The red curve and shaded band show the mean and 90% confidence interval from 10^4 toy Monte-Carlo simulations assuming a spatially uniform trap distribution. We see good agreement between the simulation and the data.

A trap is identified as “good” if it meets the following criteria. First, the trap maximum intensity must be greater than 3σ , where σ is the square root of the variance of the charge in the surrounding 35×35 pixels (trap should be bright enough). Second the relative error on

the fit τ must be less than 50% and the maximum of the intensity should be less than three times the error on the intensity (the error bars shouldn't be too big.). Third, the p-value associated with the χ^2 goodness of fit test should be greater than 0.05. Following this selection, 3379 traps are identified as “good”.

[ansh: maybe we talk about some of the bad traps we saw?]

IV. TRAP TEMPERATURE DEPENDENCE AND ENERGY

For a given charge trap we model the emission time τ_e as a function of lattice temperature T , the thermal velocity of the charge carriers v_{th} , the effective density of states in the conduction band N_c , the trap energy E_c and the trap cross-section σ [17, 18, 22, 23]. This gives:

$$\tau_e = \frac{1}{\sigma v_{th} N_c} e^{\frac{E_t}{k_B T}}, \quad (2)$$

where the temperature dependent v_{th} and N_c are defined as

$$v_{th} = \sqrt{\frac{3k_B T}{m_{cond}}} \quad \text{and} \quad N_c = 2 \left[2\pi m_{dens} \frac{k_B T}{h^2} \right]^{3/2}. \quad (3)$$

here, h is the Planck's constant, $m_{cond} \simeq 0.41 m_e$ and $m_{dens} \simeq 0.94 m_e$ are the holes effective mass for conductivity and density of states respectively between 100 and 200 K [24], and m_e is the electron mass at rest.

For the traps identified as “good,” we further track the intensity fits for the same trap across different temperatures. By fitting all of these curves with Eq. 1, we can obtain τ_e for each trap as a function of the temperature T . This allows us to fit these measurements with Eq. 2. We then mark a trap as “well-behaved” if they are within our analysis range, namely if they have at least four good temperature fits. Traps that do not satisfy this criteria either have behavior that does not match our model, or (more often) have emission time peaks that are either much shorter or much longer than the tested range. This further narrows down our total number of analyzed traps to 2121 “well-behaved” traps. An example of a well-behaved trap is shown in Fig. 2.

We then fit according to Eq. 2 to find the energy and cross-section for these well-behaved traps. For visualization purposes we classify the well-behaved traps into three observational groups based on the mean temperature at which they were directly measured: Group A (~ 50 traps) consists of traps measured primarily above 170 K; Group C (~ 50 traps) are those measured primarily below 130 K; and the remaining ~ 2000 traps form Group B. As a reminder, the motivation of this work is to study the predicted backgrounds from these traps at 135 K, and of particular interest are the traps with very

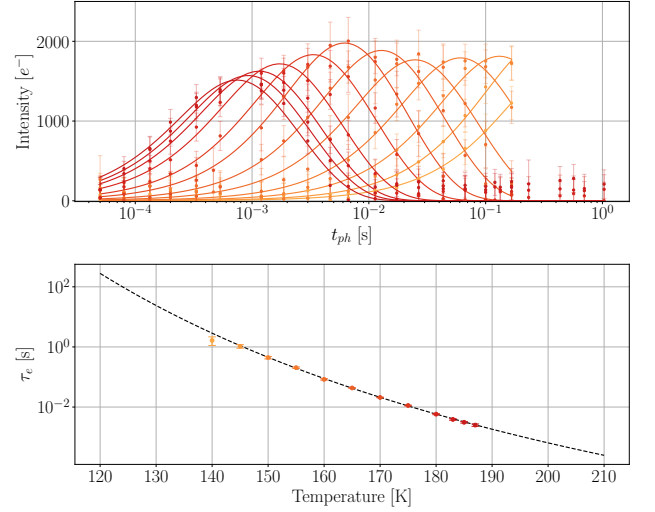


FIG. 2. An example of a well characterized charge trap in quadrant 1 of our CCD is shown. The **top** figure shows the intensity (in units of electron charge) vs t_{ph} with error bars and the fit according to 1. The **bottom** plot shows the temperature vs the fitted τ_e for the same trap with the fit line from 2. The points are colored by temperature.

long emission times at such low temperatures. To study this region in particular, we took more measurements at high temperatures to extrapolate the emission time of these traps at low temperatures. Figure 3 shows all of our energy and cross-section fits. The shaded gray region begins where we no longer have direct measurements of τ_e for any trap, all lines in this region are extrapolated from fitting with Eq. 2. The white region denotes the measured trap emission times. The longer delay times and high temperature measurements done underground at MINOS allow us to probe significantly higher energies and cross-sections than previously [18]. We also continue to see that the energy and cross-section of these traps are highly correlated. [ansh: need to think about what to put here.]

These fits were then used to predict the characteristic emission times for all well-behaved traps at 135 K, the typical operating temperature of SENSEI@SNOLAB [8]. This is shown in the top panel of Fig. 4. Here we see that we begin to measure some of the traps with large emission times, however a majority of the traps with longer delay times are extrapolated from observing these traps at high temperatures. We see that this distribution agrees with results from [18], and suggests that traps with very long delay times seem to be quite rare.

Not all traps have direct τ_e measurements at every temperature. At a given temperature T , a trap's emission time is classified as *measured* if its dipole peak falls within the sampled t_{ph} range, and as *extrapolated* if $\tau_e(T)$ is obtained solely from the fit to Eq. 2. We define the measurement efficiency $\varepsilon(\tau)$ as the fraction of trap emission times with a direct measurement in a given τ bin, pooled

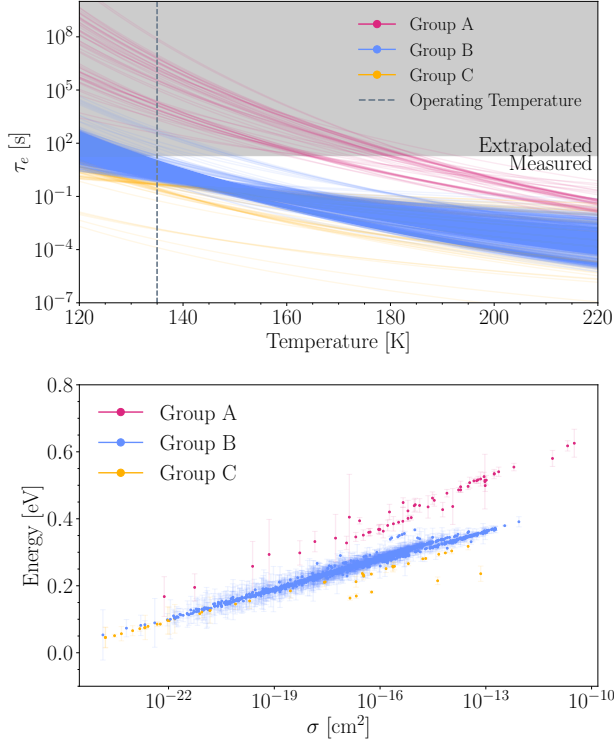


FIG. 3. All 2121 well-characterized traps, colored by observational group (A: pink, B: blue, C: yellow). **Top:** Emission time τ_e as a function of temperature. Solid portions of each line indicate temperatures at which the trap was directly measured; the shaded gray region marks the extrapolated regime where no trap has a direct measurement at any temperature. The dashed vertical line marks the SENSEI@SNOLAB operating temperature of 135 K. **Bottom:** Fitted trap energy E_t vs. capture cross-section σ for the same traps. A strong positive correlation between E_t and σ is observed across all groups.

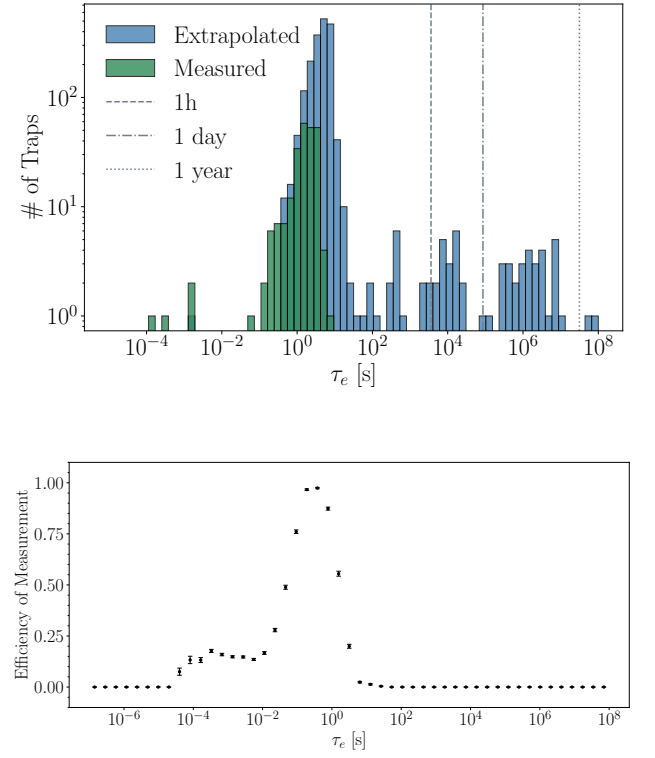


FIG. 4. **Top:** Histogram of the predicted emission time τ_e at 135 K for all 2121 well-characterized traps. Green bars indicate traps for which τ_e was directly measured; blue bars indicate traps extrapolated using Eq. 2. Vertical lines mark 1 hour, 1 day, and 1 year. **Bottom:** Measurement efficiency $\varepsilon(\tau)$, defined as the fraction of trap emission times with a direct measurement in a given τ bin, pooled across all traps and all temperatures. Error bars reflect binomial uncertainty.

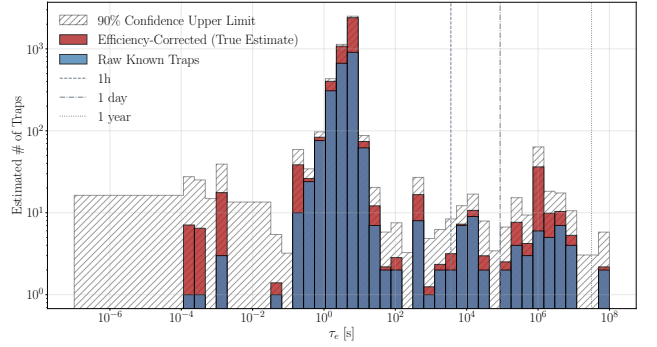


FIG. 5. Estimated trap population at 135 K accounting for measurement efficiency. Blue bars show the raw known trap counts; red bars show the efficiency-corrected estimate obtained by dividing each bin by $\varepsilon(\tau)$ at the trap's mean measurement temperature; the hatched region shows the 90% CL upper limit, derived from the Poisson upper limit on the raw counts divided by the same efficiency. Vertical lines mark 1 hour, 1 day, and 1 year.

across all traps and all temperatures. This is shown in the bottom panel of Fig. 4. The efficiency reaches near unity for $\tau \sim 0.3\text{--}1$ s, reflecting the upper end of the t_{ph} range, and falls to near zero for very short ($\tau \lesssim 10^{-5}$ s) and very long ($\tau \gtrsim 10^3$ s) emission times that lie outside our measurement window.

To account for traps that were missed due to measurement inefficiency, we apply an efficiency correction to the $\tau_e(135\text{ K})$ histogram. For each trap, we evaluate ε at τ_e at the trap's mean measurement temperature and scale the corresponding bin count by the inverse efficiency. We additionally compute a 90% CL upper limit on each bin using the Poisson upper limit on the raw counts, corrected by the same efficiency. The efficiency-corrected estimate and 90% CL upper limit are shown in Fig. 5, and are used as inputs to the simulation described in Section ??.

V. SIMULATING TRAP EMISSION

To investigate the effect of these traps on our single-electron rate we developed an end-to-end simulation architecture capable of simulating SENSEI conditions. A CCD is initialized, with a given charge trap density (taken to be the same as in this work) and a given exposure-dependent and independent single-electron rate, taken from SENSEI results from [19]. For this work we take the exposure-dependent rate to be $4.36 \times 10^{-5} e^-/\text{pix}/\text{day}$, and the exposure independent rate as $9.94 \times 10^{-5} e^-/\text{pix}/\text{image}$. Each charge trap is assigned an emission time τ_e sampled from the distribution shown in Fig. 4. A “fake” image can then be taken for a given exposure. This randomly inserts single electron events calculated from a poissonian fluctuation around the predicted number of single electron events from the exposure-independent and exposure dependent rates. Then a number of high energy events (referring to the actual event and a surrounding 60 pix radius) scaled by the exposure are sampled from a reference MINOS CCD image and then randomly placed in the image. Then readout is simulated row by row with delay times corresponding to the actual time it takes to read out a full unbinned image. Readout is then simulated such that if charge passes through a trap, it is instantly captured, and then released with probability $P = 1 - e^{-\frac{dt}{\tau_e}}$ where dt tracks the change in time. Traps are allowed to remain trapped in one image and emit in future images. A single trial refers to an initialized CCD where a sequence of 5 images at exposure times of 0 h, 4 h, 6 h, 10 h, and 20 h is repeated 100 times, for a total of 500 images per trial. After images are taken, we apply a set of masks developed in previous analyses [7, 8, 19]. We specifically apply the halo mask (60 pixel radius around pixel with $> 100e^-$), vertical bleed mask (all pixels above pixel with $> 100e^-$ are masked) and the hot column and hot pixel masks. As the latter two are data driven, to avoid truncation bias an A/B strategy is implemented, where half the simulation set is designated as set A, and the other half as set B. The set B statistics are used to decide the hot columns and pixels in A, and vice versa.

After masking, the single electron densities are calculated for all exposures. They are then fit to obtain exposure-independent and exposure-dependent rates. To obtain sufficient statistics we take 500 such trials, resulting in 250,000 images. The simulation is run under two sets of observational conditions: MINOS conditions, corresponding to the environment of this study, and SNOLAB conditions, which assume a factor of 2 fewer high-energy events per exposure to reflect the greater overburden at SNOLAB [8]. We find that with all masks applied the effect of traps on the exposure-independent rate is $\sim 1.6 \times 10^{-7} e^-/\text{pix}/\text{image}$, and the effect on the exposure-dependent rate is $\sim 1.3 \times 10^{-7} e^-/\text{pix}/\text{day}$, both consistent with zero within the simulation’s statistical uncertainty. This can be seen in Fig. 6.

The simulation is additionally run using the 90% CL

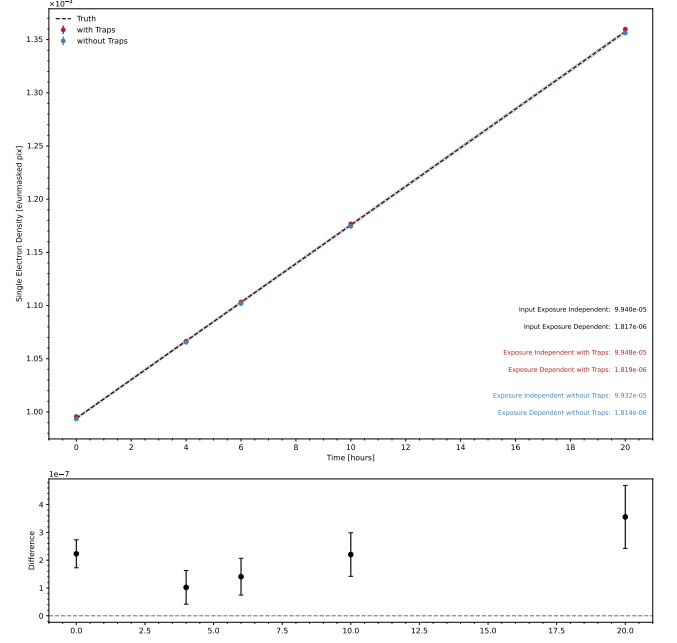


FIG. 6. Single-electron density as a function of exposure time under MINOS conditions, averaged over 500 trials. Red and blue points show the fitted exposure-independent and exposure-dependent rates with and without traps respectively; the dashed line shows the injected truth. The bottom panel shows the per-exposure difference between the with-trap and without-trap fits. The effect of traps on the exposure-independent rate is $\sim 2 \times 10^{-7} e^-/\text{pix}/\text{image}$, and the effect on the exposure-dependent rate is negligible.

upper limit trap distribution from Fig. 5 as the trap input, to bound the impact of uncharacterized traps. The results of all four scenarios — MINOS and SNOLAB conditions, each with the baseline and upper-limit trap distributions — are summarized in Fig. 7. Across all scenarios, the effect on both the exposure-independent and exposure-dependent rates remains small. Under the upper-limit trap assumption, the largest shifts are $\sim 2 \times 10^{-7} e^-/\text{pix}/\text{image}$ in the exposure-independent rate and $\sim 4 \times 10^{-7} e^-/\text{pix}/\text{day}$ in the exposure-dependent rate, both below 1% of the rate measured in [19].

As this was the same CCD as used to compare results in [19] we were able to directly test the impact of masking these traps on our measured $1e^-$ rate. We see that masking all 5171 detected traps had no significant impact on our $1e^-$ rate, supporting previous results suggesting that our masking procedures are effective at removing this background.

[ansh: Think I need to do the same MC thing done in the other traps paper with this new distribution?]

[ansh: Also missing benchmark of the increase in $1e^-$ rate from this background]

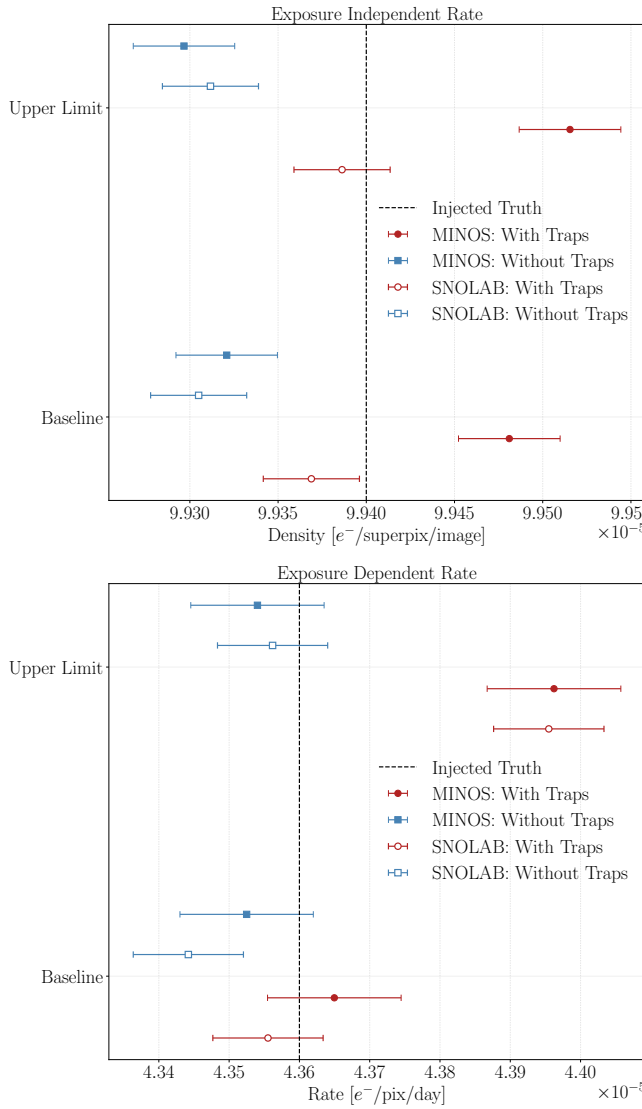


FIG. 7. Comparison of fitted single-electron rates across all four simulation scenarios. Filled (open) markers indicate MINOS (SNOLAB) conditions; red (blue) markers indicate simulations with (without) traps. Results are shown for both the baseline trap distribution (bottom two rows) and the 90% CL upper limit (top two rows). The dashed vertical line marks the injected truth. **Top:** Exposure-independent rate. **Bottom:** Exposure-dependent rate.

VI. SUMMARY AND OUTLOOK

In this work we characterized charge traps in a science-grade SENSEI Skipper-CCD operated underground in the MINOS cavern at Fermilab. We introduced a new technique for uniformly illuminating the CCD using spurious charge generated by symmetric clock swings, removing the need for an external light source. Combined with pocket-pumping over 125–210 K, this enabled the identification of 5171 traps and the full characterization of trap energy and capture cross-section for 2121 of them. The underground location was essential: the absence of

cosmic-ray-induced backgrounds permitted long, high-temperature exposures that probe trap emission times of hundreds of days at the SENSEI@SNOLAB operating temperature of 135 K, a regime previously inaccessible.

The characterized traps cluster predominantly at $\tau_e \sim 10^{-1}$ – 10^2 s at 135 K, with a tail extending to multi-day lifetimes. To bound the contribution of traps that fall outside our measurement window at all temperatures, we introduced a measurement efficiency $\varepsilon(\tau)$ pooled across all traps and temperatures, and derived a 90% CL upper limit on the trap population in each τ bin. This provides a quantitative bound on the contribution of the uncharacterized population that complements the direct characterization.

We propagated both the directly-measured and the 90% CL upper-limit trap distributions through an end-to-end CCD simulation under MINOS and SNOLAB conditions. With the standard SENSEI masking applied, the trap-induced shift in the single-electron rate is at most $\sim 2 \times 10^{-7}$ $e^-/\text{pix}/\text{image}$ in the exposure-independent component and $\sim 4 \times 10^{-7}$ $e^-/\text{pix}/\text{day}$ in the exposure-dependent component, in both cases below 1% of the rate measured in the most recent SENSEI@SNOLAB analysis [19] even under the upper-limit assumption. The shifts under SNOLAB conditions are 2–3 $\times$ smaller than under MINOS conditions, consistent with the picture that this background is sourced by charge from high-energy events being temporarily stored in traps and later released; deeper overburden suppresses the trap-mediated background alongside the primary one. This supports the conclusion of Ref. [18] that current masking strategies effectively mitigate this source of background.

These results demonstrate the value of characterizing charge traps for single-electron-sensitive experiments, and will be especially relevant for upcoming large-scale efforts such as DAMIC-M and Oscura. The spurious-charge illumination technique demonstrated here is well-suited to characterize traps in all sensors of such experiments simultaneously, without dedicated test stands. Since the trap population is expected to depend on fabrication, repeating these measurements on each new sensor batch will be important. Two features identified in this work warrant further investigation: the strong observed correlation between trap energy and capture cross-section across the full population, and the 1783 traps that did not behave according to the SRH model at any measured temperature. Understanding these populations may further refine our picture of defect-induced backgrounds in skipper-CCDs.

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